



HUSTLE STUDIO TOOLKIT

Freelance Pricing & Quote Kit

Find your floor rate, quote three packages, and keep scope under control

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Find Your Floor Rate

Your floor rate is the lowest hourly rate at which freelancing still pays you what you need. It isn't your quote. It's the line you never go below. Most new freelancers skip it and price from what feels polite, then find out in April that they underpaid themselves all year.

This chapter works through the math that the kit's calculator (`pricing-calculator.html`) and spreadsheet (`pricing-sheet.csv`) run for you, using a fully filled-in example. *Planning tool, not tax or financial advice.*

The formula

Step	What you calculate	Formula
1	Revenue needed per year	$(\text{take-home} \div (1 - \text{tax rate}) + \text{business costs}) \times (1 + \text{buffer})$
2	Billable hours per year	$\text{working weeks} \times \text{hours per week} \times \text{billable share}$
3	Floor hourly rate	$\text{revenue needed} \div \text{billable hours}$, rounded up to the nearest 5
4	Floor day rate	$\text{floor hourly} \times \text{hours per day}$

Worked example: Maya, brand designer, 2 years in

Input	Maya's value	Why
Take-home income goal (after tax)	60,000	What she wants to live on
Business costs per year	6,000	Software, hardware, insurance, accountant, courses
Effective tax rate on profit	25%	Her rough rate; check yours with an accountant
Savings buffer	10%	Covers slow months and late payers
Working weeks per year	44	52 minus holidays, public holidays and sick time
Hours worked per week	40	
Billable share	60%	The rest goes on sales, admin, invoicing, learning
Hours in a day rate	8	

Step 1. Revenue needed: $(60,000 \div 0.75 + 6,000) \times 1.10 = (80,000 + 6,000) \times 1.10 = \mathbf{94,600}$ per year.

Step 2. Billable hours: $44 \times 40 \times 0.60 = \mathbf{1,056}$ hours per year. That's not 2,080 (52×40), the number most people divide by by mistake.

Step 3. Floor hourly rate: $94,600 \div 1,056 = 89.58$, rounded up to **90 per hour**.

Step 4. Floor day rate: $90 \times 8 = \mathbf{720}$ per day. Monthly revenue target: $94,600 \div 12 \approx \mathbf{7,883}$.

If Maya had divided 66,000 by 2,080 hours, she would have charged about 32 per hour. That's barely a third of her real floor.

Floor rate vs. the rate you quote

The floor is a minimum. Once you know it:

1. **Look at your market.** Check what peers with similar experience charge, using public rate pages, community surveys in your niche, or agencies you subcontract for. If your market pays more than your floor, quote the market rate.
2. **Never quote below the floor** to win a project. Cut scope instead (see chapter 2: three tiers).
3. **Re-run the numbers every 6 months** or whenever your costs, tax situation or billable share change.

Common mistakes

- **Using 100% billable time.** Nobody bills every working hour. Under 50% is normal in your first year; 60–70% is good.
- **Forgetting tax and costs.** Your take-home goal is after tax. The revenue has to cover the tax as well.
- **Rounding down "to be competitive".** Always round up. The difference is small per hour and large per year.
- **Treating the floor as a target.** It's the line you defend, not where you aim.

Your numbers

Input	Your value
Take-home income goal	
Business costs per year	
Effective tax rate	
Savings buffer	
Working weeks per year	
Hours per week	
Billable share	
Floor hourly rate	
Floor day rate	

Quote Three Packages

A single price gives the client a yes-or-no choice. Three packages give them a choice between yeses. They compare your options with each other instead of with a cheaper freelancer, and you can protect your rate by cutting scope instead of price.

How the tiers work

Tag every task in the project with a tier:

Tier	Package	Contains
1	Essential	The core outcome the client asked for, nothing extra
2	Standard	Essential + the things that make it go smoothly (variants, docs, handover)
3	Premium	Standard + speed, support or extra reach

Each package includes every task at its tier and below. The price is:

hours × quote rate × (1 + contingency), rounded up to the nearest 50

Contingency (10–20%) covers the email, calls and small surprises that every project has. Ask for a deposit (commonly 30–50%) before you start.

Worked example: Maya quotes a brand refresh

Quote rate: **90/hour** (her floor; she could quote higher). Contingency: **15%**. Deposit: **50%**.

Task	Hours	Tier
Discovery call & brief	2	1
Core deliverable (logo refresh + palette)	12	1
Two revision rounds	4	1
Extra deliverable (social media kit)	6	2
Handover documentation (mini brand guide)	2	2
Priority support (30 days)	5	3

Package	Hours	Calculation	Price	Deposit
Essential	18	$18 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 1,863$	1,900	950
Standard	26	$26 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 2,691$	2,700	1,350
Premium	31	$31 \times 90 \times 1.15 = 3,208.50$	3,250	1,625

The quote text (filled in)

Hi Sam,

Thanks for the call on Tuesday. Here are three ways we can do the brand refresh:

Essential: 1,900. Discovery, refreshed logo and colour palette, two rounds of revisions.

Standard: 2,700. Everything in Essential plus a social media kit and a mini brand guide your team can use. **Premium: 3,250.** Everything in Standard plus 30 days of priority support after launch.

Most clients in your position choose Standard. A 50% deposit starts the work; the balance is due on delivery. This quote is valid until 30 November.

Not included: copywriting, printing, and website changes. I'm happy to quote these separately.

Best, Maya

Rules that protect your rate

- 1. **If they push back on price, remove scope, never just the number.** "If budget is the concern, Essential gets you the core result for 1,900."
- 2. **Put the package you want them to pick in the middle** and say which one most clients choose, but only if it's true.
- 3. **Always write a validity date.** It gives a gentle deadline and lets you update prices later.
- 4. **Always list what's not included.** Chapter 3 shows you how.

Your quote

Task	Hours	Tier

Scope & Change Orders

A good quote can still lose money if the scope is vague. This chapter gives you the five documents that keep a project at the size you priced it: a scope section, a kickoff recap, a change order, a change log, and reply scripts. Replace everything in [brackets].

Templates only, not legal advice. For large contracts, have a lawyer review your terms.

1. Scope of work section

Paste this into your proposal or quote.

Project: [Project name] **Goal:** [One sentence on what the finished work should achieve for the client.]

Included

- [Deliverable 1, with a number, e.g. "Design of 5 pages: Home, About, Services, Blog index, Contact"]
- [Deliverable 2, e.g. "Build in WordPress on the client's existing hosting"]
- [Deliverable 3, e.g. "Entry of client-supplied text and images"]
- Revisions: [2] rounds of consolidated feedback per deliverable
- Meetings: [1] kickoff call + [2] check-in calls of up to [30] minutes
- Support: [14] days of bug fixes after launch

Not included (available as add-ons on request)

- [Copywriting or editing of text]
- [Stock photos or paid fonts/plugins, billed at cost if needed]
- [Additional pages beyond the 5 listed]
- [Ongoing maintenance, hosting or updates after the support period]
- [SEO, ads or analytics setup]

Client responsibilities

- Provide [text, images, logins] by [date]
- Send consolidated feedback (one email per round) within [3] working days
- Delays in client materials or feedback move the delivery date by the same amount

Additional work: anything not listed under "Included" is quoted separately before work starts, at [rate]/hour or as a fixed price agreed in writing through a change order. Rush work (delivery earlier than the agreed timeline) carries a [25]% fee.

Tip: aim for 3–5 "Not included" bullets. Choose the things clients in your field most often assume are included.

2. Kickoff recap email

Subject: [Project]: kickoff recap and next steps

Hi [Name],

Great to get started. A quick recap so we're on the same page:

- What I'm delivering: [short list]
- Revisions: [2] rounds per deliverable, with feedback collected into one email per round
- Timeline: [milestone 1, date] → [milestone 2, date] → launch [date]
- What I need from you: [materials] by [date]
- Not included this time: [the 2–3 most likely assumptions]

If something comes up that's outside this list, I'll quote it before I start, so there are never surprises on the invoice.

Looking forward to it, [Your name]

3. Change order (filled example)

Field	Example
Change order #	1
Project	Brand refresh for Northwind Bakery
Date	14 October
Original agreement	Proposal "Standard package", 2 October
Requested change	Design an extra FAQ page in the same style as the existing pages
Not included in this change	Writing the FAQ copy (client supplies the text)
Estimate	4 hours, including communication
Price impact	+425 · new project total 3,125
Timeline impact	Delivery moves from 28 October to 30 October
Payment	Added to the final invoice

All other terms of the original agreement stay the same. **Approved by:** _____

Date: _____ (a reply email saying "approved" also counts)

How to price a change: estimated hours × (1 + overhead, typically 10–20%) × your rate × rush multiplier (1.0 normal, 1.25 rush, 1.5 urgent), rounded up. Example: $4 \times 1.15 \times 90 \times 1.0 = 414$, rounded up to **425**.

4. Change log

Keep one per project and share it at each milestone.

#	Date	Request (who asked)	In scope?	Hours	Price	Status
1	14 Oct	Extra FAQ page (Sam)	No	4	425	Approved CO #1
2	16 Oct	Button colour tweak (Sam)	Small	0.25	0	Done, absorbed (noted)
3	20 Oct	Newsletter template (Lee)	No	5	525	Quoted

Why keep one: small favours you absorb become visible. When they add up, you can bundle them into one change order and have the evidence ready.

5. Reply scripts

A. A small favour you absorb

"Done! That one was outside our scope but quick, so no charge this time. For anything else beyond scope I'll send a short quote first."

B. A new feature

"Good idea. It isn't in the current scope, so there are two options: add it now for [price] (delivery moves to [date]), or do it as phase 2 after launch so the current date holds. Which would you prefer? I'll send a change order."

C. An extra revision round

"We've used the [2] included rounds. Further rounds are [price] each. Reply 'go ahead' and I'll start today."

D. The deadline moves earlier

"Here are the options: full scope by [new date] with a [amount] rush fee; core items by [new date] and the rest on the original date at no extra cost; or we keep [date]."

E. A pile-up of small requests

"I've listed the extra requests from the past few weeks: [list]. Together they come to about [X] hours. I suggest one change order for [price]. Once it's approved, I'll fold them into the next delivery."

F. Asked on a call

"Let me check how that fits the scope and come back to you by email today."

Never agree to a price or timeline live. Confirm it in writing.

Questions or problems: chenphien@gmail.com